Relationships

Living things in an ecosystem interact in different ways. Some living things have learned to depend on each other to survive.

Collaboration

Animals of the same species may live in groups, rather than on their own. A group of animals from the same species is called a **population**. As a population, animals can share the jobs of finding food and water, protecting each other from predators, raising their young and finding shelter. This is called **collaboration**. It means 'working together'.

Symbiotic relationships

Certain species develop a relationship with a completely different species that benefits one or both animals. This is called a **symbiotic relationship**. When the symbiotic relationship benefits both species it is called **mutualism**. An example is the clownfish, which lives amongst the poisonous tentacles of a sea anemone. The clownfish protects the anemone from the bigger fish that eat anemones. In return, the clownfish is protected from predators by the anemone's stinging tentacles. The clownfish is not hurt because it has a special mucus on its skin that protects it from the sting.

☞ **1** Words from the text have been broken into syllables and the letters have been scrambled. Unscramble the syllables and put the words back together. Write each word next to its definition.

Scrambled syllables	**Word**	**Definition**
ed / pedn		It means 'rely'.
mys / ib / o / cit		It describes a relationship that benefits one or both species.
rsu / viev		It means 'stay alive'.
co / ball / o / ra / toni		It means the process of working together.
op / up / la / iton		It means a group of animals from the same species.

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Relationships CONT'D

Parasitic relationships

Some living things have a relationship where one is a **host** and the other is a **parasite**. Fleas are common parasites. Fleas are found on the bodies of furry animals, including rats and dogs. These parasites benefit by feeding on the blood of the host. The host gains nothing from the relationship at all. The host may feel itchy and can become weak, miserable and even sick from too many fleas. We call too many parasites in one place an **infestation**.

Parasites such as fleas and ticks feed on the blood of many types of mammals. Other parasites may feed on flesh (skin tissue), hair proteins, sweat or salts.

2 Write the living things from the word bank into the table, showing which ones are parasites on which hosts. An example has been done for you. Hint: Some living things may host more than one type of parasite, and some parasites are found on more than one type of host.

Hosts	Parasites
dogs	ticks, sandflies

Word bank

fleas

birds

humans

lice

cats

fish

barnacles

dogs

mosquitoes

sandflies

ticks

3 Name four things that parasites might eat.

_____ _____

_____ _____

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